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Policy and practice : exploring the potentials of social practice theory for policy studies

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Policy and practice: exploring the potentials of social practice theory for policy studies

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ABSTRACT

Social sciences have seen a so-called practice turn, moving beyond a preoccupation with individual attitudes and behaviour towards the more contextually-embedded concept of social practices to understand drivers and change levers of social action. However, in the policy sciences engagement with Social Practice Theories (SPT) is relatively scarce. Approaches and studies endorsing behaviourist approaches continue to outnumber more sociological, relational perspectives, including SPT. Behaviourist and SPT approaches rest on divergent understandings of social action and change, with contrasting implications for understanding the impact of policy alternatives and the policy processes. In this article, we stimulate discussion on how wider use of SPT – as developed in the field of sociology – in public policy can advance understanding of the dynamics of policy impact and policymaking. Based on a systematic review of current applications of SPT in public administration journals we identify the motivations for and scope of SPT in policy research, after which we propose a research agenda along two streams of theorization which may benefit from engaging more thoroughly with SPT: (i) the practices of target groups, and (ii) the practices of policy work and public administration.

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1. Introduction

Public policy is central to everyday lives, but how can we understand the impact of public policies on everyday social actions? How can research inform effective policymaking to steer social actions? And how do policymakers select options for policy design? These questions have been of crucial concern to scholars of public policy whose focus is on understanding and informing governance and policy interventions aimed at changing social actions to the benefit of society (e.g. James and Jorgensen 2009). Policy interventions must be capable of influencing actions of street-level bureaucrats, stakeholders, citizens, or specific target groups to change existing patterns of action. Examples include police officers stopping racial profiling (e.g. Baumgartner et al. 2021), farmers adopting

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sustainable modes of food production (e.g. Armstrong and Kamieniecki 2019), or consumers making healthier or more sustainable food choices (Schober 2022; Wensing et al. 2024). Despite the – oftentimes widely shared – need for such collective change, the stickiness of many hard-to-change and routine practices, such as those outlined in these examples, shows that steering social action towards desired directions remains a paramount task.

In seeking to address this challenge, different disciplinary and conceptual positions put forward distinct, often contrasting understandings about the nature of human behaviour and how to change it. Since the early 2000s, public administration and policy scholars have increasingly turned to insights from behavioural psychology to understand how to stimulate behaviour change (Ewert, Loer, and Thomann 2021). These approaches mostly highlight cognitive and psychological factors, such as bounded rationality, cognitive biases, attitudes and beliefs, as crucial in shaping behaviour and how people respond to policy interventions (Grimmelikhuijsen et al. 2017; Rawat 2019). The integration of these insights into the field has resulted in the emergence of a branch of scholarship that is referred to as behavioural public administration, or behavioural public policy (e.g. Chater and Loewenstein 2023; Grimmelikhuijsen et al. 2017).

Behavioural approaches to public policy – which predominantly focus on psychological mechanisms of the individual as key determinants of behaviour – have offered some valuable insights to both scholars and policymakers. Policies resulting from these insights focus on interventions that target attitudes, knowledge and the decision-making of citizens in order to bring about desired behaviours. A popular behavioural approach is that of "nudging" (Gopalan and Pirog 2017), such as campaigns on the provision of information to consumers to nudge them to make more informed healthy or sustainable consumer choices (Thaler and Sunstein 2008).

However, despite some positive behaviour change associated with behaviourist-informed policies – such as the effects of alternative food labels on more healthy and sustainable consumption (e.g. Ebeling and Lotz 2015; Rawat 2019) – overall, decades of policy informed by behaviourist insights have not achieved the desired outcomes. Issues such as unsustainable consumption, obesity, and other health and sustainability-related problems are persisting or even rising. Behavioural governance interventions, such as nudging, often only have a limited effect in changing the behaviour of individuals, with positive effects often being partial to those who already have motivations to change (e.g. Goodwin 2012; Lodge and Wegrich 2016). Following this, behaviourist-inspired interventions have been frequently criticised in the social sciences for being overly focused on the individual, while not adequately addressing structural causes of social problems (e.g. Shove 2010), and having unintended negative consequences not predicted or captured by their concepts and models (e.g. Moser 2012). The pervasiveness of behaviourism in both modern public institutions and government research teams, is reflected in the dominant focus on notions of (bounded) rationality and targeting individual choices and decision-making in policy interventions (Straßheim 2020). In this regard, behavioural public policy has been detached from developments in other social sciences, which benefit from alternative analytical perspectives that better capture the role of structural forces and contexts in shaping and scripting action (Feitsma and Whitehead 2022).

Other fields of social science, in particular environmental sociology, have seen a shift from individualist, rationalist assumptions associated with behaviourism toward

alternative theories of social change accounting for *social* and *structural* elements in explanations of human behaviour. Inspired by the work of scholars such as Anthony Giddens and Pierre Bourdieu, a central perspective has been to move beyond individual attitudes, behaviour and choice (often referred to as the "ABC" model of behaviour change – see Shove 2010) toward broader and more embedded approaches that consider and capture complex social forces shaping action. In particular, social practice theories have made a significant influence in this regard. While there is not one, but many theories of social practice, they are united in a key proposition: instead of looking toward individuals' attitudes, beliefs, values or behaviours as units of analysis, drivers of social change are understood as located in the "site of the social" (Schatzki 2002) with practices as the fundamental unit of analysis (see also Schatzki 1996). Social practice theories aim to overcome the long-standing structure and agency chasm in the social sciences by connecting micro and macro approaches. They do so by focusing on the analysis of social practices as a means of studying the interrelations between routinised, situated conduct and wider socio-technical transformations. Within fields relating to sociology of the environment (e.g. Shove and Spurling 2013), resource consumption (e.g. Warde 2005), and health (e.g. Delormier, Frohlich, and Potvin 2009), social practice theories have proliferated and demonstrated their potential in advancing understanding of complex social, cultural, material and political-economic processes shaping action, while also providing concrete avenues for change (Spurling and McMeekin 2015; Strengers 2011).

Although practice-oriented perspectives have gained some traction in public administration and policy studies – for instance, in the work of scholars such as Hal Colebatch (2006) and Hendrik Wagenaar (2004) – these applications typically invoke "practice" in a more generic sense, often without engaging with the more fully developed social practice theorization emerging from sociology. As Bartels (2018) notes, many of these contributions refer to policy work or decision-making as forms of practice, but do not conceptualise practices themselves as socially shared, materially mediated configurations of activity, nor do they explore how practices emerge, persist, and change over time (cf. Kurz et al. 2015).

In this paper, we aim to address this disconnect by systematically exploring how Social Practice Theory – as developed by scholars such as Schatzki and Shove – can enrich policy and public administration theorization. Our goal is not to review all work loosely related to practice, but to examine how this particular sociological body of social practice theory (hereafter referred to as SPT) can inform empirical and conceptual work on policy, thereby helping to bridge the persistent theory-practice gap in the field (e.g. Cooke et al. 2021; Turnbull 2006; Wellstead, Cairney, and Oliver 2018).

In what follows, we first outline key assumptions underlying SPT, focusing specifically on arguments concerning critiques of rationalist and individualist behaviourist approaches. Second, based on a systematic literature review, we draw upon some of the scarce but growing applications of SPT in public administration journals to gain a better understanding of how and in what ways public administration and policy scholars have thus far adopted SPT, noting promising developments but significant gaps remaining. Finally, we integrate these insights into a research agenda for social practice-based public policy research where we identify and discuss two streams of public policy debates where SPT can be of particular added value. These include (i) the practices of target groups and (ii) the practices of policy work and policymaking. We end the

paper with a discussion reflecting on the potential for further engagement between policy research and the rich body of work on SPT.

2. Foundations of social practice theory

In this section, we provide an overview of the emergence of SPT as a distinct body of approaches to theorizing social action and change within the social sciences. The so-called "practice turn" (see Schatzki, Knorr-Cetina, and Savigny 2001) has emerged in response to the perceived limitations of dualisms left unresolved by other traditions and ontologies concerning the tendency to explain the world in terms of irreducible dichotomies relating to structure/actor and theory/practice in explanations concerning the conduct and analysis of social life.

As outlined, SPT is not one theory or approach, but rather a collection of approaches that share some important assumptions and concepts for understanding social activity and change. Social practice theorists argue that most actions underpinning social life are performed in taken-for-granted, habitual ways, often outside of conscious awareness. This is based on the assumption that much of everyday action is not the result of individual choices but is instead routinely performed outside the realms of discursive awareness, which is bounded by *practice intelligibility* (Schatzki 1996) and rooted in practical consciousness (Giddens 1984), or what Bourdieu (1977) called *doxa:* that which is hegemonic and taken for granted. This assumption problematies the rationalistic and cognitivist conceptualisations of action put forward by traditional behaviourist approaches, which stress that social actions are the result of the deliberative, often rational, choices of individuals.

Seminal sociologist Anthony Giddens, who has provided a basis for much contemporary theorization on social practices, sums up the fundamental premise of the practice approach when he asserts that "(t)he basic domain of study of the social sciences, is neither the experience of the individual actor, nor the existence of any form of social totality, but social practices ordered across space and time" (1984, 2).

The key proposition underlying practice theories is that individuals and groups of individuals' performance of distinct, routine and socially recognizable sets of everyday practices reproduce existing social structures (Bourdieu 1977; Giddens 1984; Schatzki 1996). In this respect, social practice theories seek to connect micro (actor) and macro (structure) approaches to social analysis by highlighting the interconnections between routinised every day or situated conduct and larger-scale institutional development (Reckwitz 2002). To this end, SPT offers a radically different conception of structure and context to that of traditional behaviourist approaches. Rather than conceptualizing context as an external variable that throws up barriers to behaviour, SPT approaches reconceptualise context as constitutive of, and inseparable from, social practices (Greene and Rau 2018). Such a shift in conceptualization is considered crucial as social practices are considered more broadly conceived than a focus on individuals' habits and behaviours, placing them within both a specific social and a historical context, thereby recognizing how "individual choices are framed by contemporary trends and the development of such trends over time and space" (Barr and Prillwitz 2014, 7). This focus on practices implies studying the embodied, material, temporal, and spatial organization of social action, but also demands a notion of the elements

that constitute practices. Reckwitz (2002, 249–250), laying a foundation for theories of social practices, defines practices as a composition of a unique set of elements and highlights processes of routinization in their (re)production:

> A 'practice' (…) is a routinised type of behaviour which consists of several elements, interconnected to one another: forms of bodily activities, forms of mental activities, 'things' and their use, a background knowledge in the form of understanding, know-how, states of emotion and motivational knowledge.

Similarly, Shove, Pantzar, and Watson (2012) conceptualise social practices as comprised of three sets of elements: meanings, *competences* and *materials*. Individuals become "carriers" of practice not only through skilled bodily behaviour, but also by reproducing tacit understandings, know how, and aspirations that are socially and culturally shaped (Reckwitz 2002; Shove, Pantzar, and Watson 2012; Warde 2005). From this perspective, SPT-informed research analyses how practices how practices attract, recruit and maintain practitioners, and how they become more or less durable or resistant to change (Warde 2005).

In addition to studying how practices are integrated and performed, SPT has emphasised the relations between social practices. Practices interconnect into bundles, complexes or "nexus" of practices (Hui, Schatzki, and Shove 2016; Shove, Pantzar, and Watson 2012). Practices can be connected in pairs or bundles through shared meanings, ideologies, materials, spatial and socio-technical arrangements. These links emerge and dissolve over time, shaping the "stickiness" of complexes that lock social action into certain pathways. For instance, infrastructural development has reconfigured practices of mobility and consumption, contributing to car dependence through processes of spatial distancing (Shove, Watson, and Spurling 2015). As Shove and Walker (2014, 47) highlight, an important focal point for practice researchers is "detailing precisely how social practices, and bundles and constellations of practice, hang together and identifying the material, social and governing arrangements amidst which they 'transpire' (…) sustain and reproduce".

While the practice turn has also influenced public administration and policy studies, many of these contributions employ the notion of "practice" in a broader or more descriptive way. Influential interpretive scholars such as Rein (1976), Colebatch (2006), Wagenaar and Hajer (1995; Hajer and Wagenaar 2003) have emphasised policymaking as situated, discursive and interpretive practice, highlighting how policy is enacted through discourse, negotiation and the situated judgements of administrators. These perspectives have been important in challenging the abstract, rationalist models of policymaking and in foregrounding the practical knowledge involved in administrative work. However, they do not engage with the sociological tradition of SPT, which conceptualises practices as materially mediated, socially shared configurations of elements and provides a systemic account of how practices are reproduced, interconnected and transformed over time. This distinction is crucial in our review: rather than examining practice-orientated perspectives writ large, our focus is on SPT as a coherent and influential tradition developed in sociology, and the particular insights it offers for advancing policy studies.

In summary, SPT has made significant advancements in understanding social change through relational, contextual and performative concepts. Practices can be explored and

analysed through methodological and analytical moves of zooming in and out of different scales and perspectives (Nicolini 2009), from micro-level, embodied performances to macro-level systems of practice. These shared assumptions of SPT offer a clear contrast with the rational and individualistic assumptions underpinning behavioural public administration.

3. Reviewing social practice approaches in public administration and policy scholarship

In this section, we discuss existing applications of social practice theory in public administration and policy scholarship. The goal of this review is to synthesise why and how public administration and policy scholars use social practice theories in their work to date, including specific attention to authors' rationales for choosing to apply SPT, and the methodological consequences of using SPT. Following this, we outline our reflections on what this means for future public policy inquiry by setting out a research agenda.

To compile the state-of-the-art, we reviewed contributions to all 43 English language journals listed under the category "Public Administration" in the Web of Science 2018 Journal Citation Reports (see Appendix 1).[1] We searched the websites of each of these journals on 6 April 2020 using the query "social practice*", which allowed us to identify studies that explicitly mention or refer to *social* practice theorization in the full text. This initial search resulted in 260 papers, see appendix 1. Subsequently, all titles and abstracts were evaluated for eligibility along two inclusion and exclusion criteria:

1. Include only peer-reviewed papers (including literature reviews); excluding book reviews, conference papers, etc.
2. Include only English language papers; excluding papers in other languages.

Following the application of these exclusion and inclusion criteria at the title and abstract level, 58 articles remained. From this selection, we only included articles that, after closer examination, explicitly use and conceptualise a SPT approach. Articles that do not apply such an approach or refer to practices without providing a theoretically grounded conceptualization social practices, were excluded.

Following this protocol, we ended up with 18 publications that apply and conceptualise a social practice approach. The journals with the highest number of publications were *Environment and Planning C* (n = 5) and *Science and Public Policy* (n = 4), followed by *Policy Sciences* (n = 3). See Appendix 2 for a complete overview.

Geographically, most research is done by scholars from Anglo-Saxon and Northern European countries, with most lead authors coming from the UK (6), Netherlands (3), and Finland (2). Others are from Norway, Denmark, Austria, Canada, New Zealand, Australia and the USA. Looking at the cases studied in this publications, we see a similar picture, with two exceptions studying Ghana (Sarpong, Botchie, and Dey 2018) and Mexico (Wilshusen 2009).

The final set of publications was read closely in order to analyse the rationales of the authors to use SPT. More specifically, we identified the reported motivations to use SPT, the objective and scope of the papers, and the methodological consequences. As a second step we categorised the motivations for using SPT into thematic groups, where the

articles' objectives and scope are used to exemplify the various contributions within each group. In a separate section we report on the methodological considerations that were present in the selected publications.

4. Rationales and applications of social practice theory in public administration and policy

In our review, we identified two recurring motivational themes that correspond to policy debates in which practice-based approaches have been suggested as a valuable perspective: (i) as an alternative to the behavioural foundations of policy interventions, and (ii) as an alternative or addition to rationalist understandings of the policy process. Below, we reveal how these motivations for using SPT are featured in the publications reviewed, and provide some examples to illustrate their respective insights. After exploring the potential and premises of SPT in these debates, we discuss the methodological consequences of a social practice perspective which are raised in some of the reviewed publications and relate this to larger methodological debates in SPT. Subsequently we use these motivations as input for a social practice-based research agenda.

4.1 An alternative to behavioural foundations

The most persistent motivation for using an SPT approach is that it addresses limitations and criticisms of behaviourist understandings of social action and the impact of policies thereon. Many of the papers reviewed reject "simplistic linear cognitive models" (Naus and van der Horst 2016; Seyfang and Haxeltine 2012, 394; Strengers 2011) and adhere to Shove's argument to go "beyond the ABC" (Shove 2010). In doing so, they share the idea that focusing solely on the behaviour of individuals limits the scope of a meaningful understanding of social change. To this, across the accounts, two main arguments for why the ontological choice for studying practices has implications for policy design and analysis are present.

The first argument is that, in contrast to focusing on individual behaviours, peoples' actions are understood as always socially embedded and intertwined within a nexus of practices, and therefore cannot be studied in isolation (Barr and Prillwitz 2014). As a result, practices cannot be seen distinctly from how social and physical environments are structured. For example, the use of a car depends on priorities of spatial planning shaping the location and accessibility of sites and services necessary for daily life, including shops, supermarkets, workplaces, and residential areas. These situational factors, which coevolve with the evolution of mobility practices, tend to be overlooked when limiting the scope of analysis to the individual. Consequently, Barr and Prillwitz (2014, 5) argue that current policy approaches inspired by behaviourism, such as social marketing and nudging, supress larger discussions concerning more radical social and structural changes required to support transitions in behaviour.

The second argument relates to differential assumptions between behaviourist and SPT perspectives concerning the origins or drivers of change in social actions. In this regard, Kammerlander et al. (2020) emphasise that behavioural approaches tend to "highlight self-reflection and self-awareness as triggers of pro environmental behavioural change," while social practice theories "assume that a 'disruption' of the practice-

performing process or a change of settings will lead to a reflection on current behaviour or habit" (129). Building upon the work of Spurling and McMeekin (2015), Kammerlander et al. exemplify how SPT insights can help to change practices through three different mechanisms: recrafting practices, substituting practices, and understanding how practices interlock.

Recrafting entails the reshaping of existing practices in order to make them more efficient and sustainable. Policymakers can focus on recrafting specific practices by concentrating on intervening in and circulating new elements (meanings, materials and forms of competence), of a specific practice. Substituting involves the replacement of one practice with another, for example a resource-intensive practice (e.g. car driving) is substituted for a more sustainable one (e.g. cycling). Interlocking means understanding how practices are related and affect each other. As practices interlock, change to one practice may stimulate changes in others. For example, taking a bike instead of a car not only affects commuting practices, but also (food) shopping, individual health or exercise practices.

Interlocking thus includes recognizing how practices connect and bundle together to make up daily lives. An interlocking perspective may involve considering how work, school and family practices intersect to configure certain patterns of practice and resource use, shaping how different target groups respond to interventions. From an interlocking perspective, to successfully change a practice, policies also need to consider and target other practices to which the desired target practice is connected. For example, intervening in a practice such as mobility would entail moving beyond a focus on singular practices, such as that of car driving, to centre on recrafting those practices with which mobility interlocks, including those relating to the provisioning of housing, the location of schools and the ways in which work and leisure activities are structured (Spurling and McMeekin 2015; in Kammerlander et al. 2020). Considering these three intervention perspectives (that is, recrafting, substituting and changing how practices interlock), a practice-inspired approach to policy entails targeting elements, links and bundles of practices to change, redirect, relocate and reconfigure these constituent and relational dynamics of practice towards more sustainable configurations.

Across the papers reviewed, SPT was predominantly drawn on to understand daily consumption practices of target group audiences in the domains of mobility (Barr and Prillwitz 2014), energy consumption (Kammerlander et al. 2020; Naus and van der Horst 2016; Strengers 2011), or both (Seyfang and Haxeltine 2012). In order to illustrate the need to consider how practices interlink and co-shape each other, Kammerlander et al. studied climate change mitigation policy, looking at policy instruments for CO2 emission reduction. Their insights show that there is great potential in reducing CO2 emission by altering the contexts of performance of social practices, for example by reducing the need for using private vehicles by changing (supplementing or re-crafting) mobility practices through expansions of public transportation schemes, or changing the allocation of work and job opportunities (331).

Focusing on recrafting practices and their arrangements contrasts with behaviourist approaches, which are more likely to address individual environmental attitudes and choices, for example by providing incentives to reduce individual car usage by additional taxes, or smartphone apps to encourage physical activity (e.g. Hilton et al. 2014). A potential risk for the applicability of SPT-based policy interventions, however, is the

scope of change. SPT scholars themselves often acknowledge that policy recommendations based on SPT will "require a fundamental shift in the political culture […] and would be likely to necessitate major changes to economic and social systems" (Barr and Prillwitz 2014, 14). These types of structural policy changes are often perceived as politically unfeasible or needing to be dealt with at a different scale or a higher level of governance.

4.2 Moving beyond rational choice in the policy process

In addition to studying the daily consumption practices of citizens, a second motivation for scholars for applying SPT in public administration has been to move beyond rational-institutionalist models of the policy process (e.g. Åm 2013; Niinikoski and Kuhlmann 2014; Turnbull 2006). Studies on policymaking and implementation tend to be dominated by rational-institutionalist approaches, with a focus on the design of rules, (institutional) path dependency, and rational human agents (e.g. Kay 2005; Ostrom 2007). Studying the social practices of policy practitioners offers a more context sensitive and alternative understanding of how governance acts are formulated and applied (e.g. Turnbull 2006).

The idea that the everyday activities of government officials, policy implementers, and other bureaucrats, shape policy design and outcomes in the present and future, instead of rational linear top-down policy process, is not limited to SPT. and has been highlighted by renowned public administration contributions, such as Lindblom (1959), Lipsky (1980), and Pressman and Wildavsky (1984). These classic texts provide comprehensive analyses of the activities of policy practitioners within the contexts in which they operate and show the messiness of policy work, and how this shapes policy implementation (Bartels 2018). Moreover, as noted in Section 2, also classic interpretive perspectives in the field op public administration (e.g. Colebatch 2006; Hajer 1995; Wagenaar 2004) have highlighted the contingent and situated character of policy work. However, these studies do not take a social practice theory approach as envisioned by the practice turn in the social sciences, with its distinct ontological and epistemological foundations as discussed earlier in this paper.

From the articles in our review, Turnbull (2006) builds on Colebatch and Wagenaar's call for greater attention to the practices of policymaking, showing that policymakers' understandings of problems are shaped less by rational calculations than by routine ways of dealing with issues in existing practices.

Niinikoski and Kuhlmann (2014) similarly argue that policymaking is not a rational and linear process, but is constituted by discursive and extra-discursive practices. Discursive practice refers to "a set of rules that guides who is authorised to use what and how" (89), while extra-discursive practices are understood as material resources that can direct discourses. Niinikoski and Kuhlmann show that in order to achieve policy changes, new conceptualizations and information need to be introduced, such as adding the element of "social" to the concept of innovations through collaboration between scientists and policy practitioners. However, discursive policy practices are limited in the information they can process, and knowledge that does not fit the dominant practice is easily dismissed, which happened to ideas that did not fit the dominant techno-economic discourse on innovations in the 1980s and 1990s. Therefore, Niinikoski and Kuhlmann

conclude that changing policy practices can be a lengthy process. In addition, Åm (2013) shows that in the case of the establishment of new public institutions – in this particular case intermediary institutions mediating between science and policy on responsible nanotechnology – dominant discourses are translated and enacted into social practices within these new institutions.

Adding to this work highlighting the non-rational and performative dimensions of policymaking processes, a number of authors employ case study ethnographic approaches to reveal how social practices shape policymaking structures (Begkos, Llewellyn, and Walshe 2020; Farrelly 2009; Wilshusen, 2009). For example, Wilshusen (2009), studying deliberative forms of governance, shows that performances in public meetings regularly reflect long-standing social processes rooted in community histories and political cultures. However, these critical social and contextual aspects and their influence on governance processes are often overlooked in the design principles of such meetings. Similarly, Farrelly (2009), argues that in order to assess the democratic quality of citizen participation forums, they should be studied as sites of interaction in which social structures are contested, challenged, or reinforced. Such situated dynamics are not covered by most criteria-based schemes for assessing the quality of participatory governance, therefore overlooking latent barriers, such as the geographical location and symbolic value of venues.

Thus, across the review, we observe that public administration and policy scholars apply practice approaches as a means to overcome important limitations of other approaches for understanding social action and the processes and institutions that shape these actions. Taking a practice-theoretical ontological perspective can reveal new dimensions that help us understand social activities and how to change them. Aside from these theoretical motivations and the policy implications emerging from them, the decision to use SPT is also often reflected in specific methodological choices, which we will briefly reflect upon below.

4.3 Methodological implications

In contrast to behaviourist approaches which tend to rely on experiments and survey-based methodologies for revealing aggregate insights into patterns in individuals' attitudes, behaviours and beliefs (e.g. James, Jilke, and Ryzin 2017), adopting a practice-based orientation calls for more situated and contextual methodological tools. Although the papers in our review are not always explicit in their epistemological position, some clearly reject dominant positivist approaches, and argue in favour of social constructivist or reflexive epistemologies (e.g. Kuus 2018; Marshall and Peters 1985; Niinikoski and Kuhlmann 2014). Marshall and Peters (1985) emphasise the epistemological stance of SPT as one in which knowledge is not absolute and relies on agreements and judgments made in practice. In this sense, observations cannot be seen separately from their observers and the historical context in which they are made. Some scholars have used SPT as part of a multi-method research design. For example, Hansen and Allansdottir (2011) use Qualitative Comparative Analysis in order to take a "helicopter view" and explore which configurations of practices studied in a larger research project can help to explain the impact of participatory technology assessments.

In general, current applications of SPT outside the realm of public administration move beyond common behaviourist research methods, which are concerned with generating aggregate insights through survey or experimental methods. Instead, the practice turn in social sciences has been accompanied by a call for the systematic application of ethnographic research methods (e.g. Nicolini 2012). With many routine actions rooted in practical consciousness, practice-based understandings of social life as shaped by discursive and non-cognitive elements, such as embodied know-how, competence, and materiality bring about methodological challenges in representation (Greene and Royston 2022; Halkier and Jensen 2011). Efforts to access and represent these dimensions have resulted in a proliferation of creative verbal, observation, sensory and visual methodologies (e.g. Martens 2012; Pink 2009). Furthermore, the emphasis on understanding dynamics of change over short and longer-temporal frameworks has stimulated the development of methodologies capable of capturing these elements and their interactions over time and across space (see Greene and Royston 2022). However, others argue that quantitative methods, such as surveys, or even experiments, can be used to study practices, or suggest a combination of qualitative and quantitative methodologies in a mixed-method design (Browne et al. 2014). Thus these debates on methodological challenges associated with studying social action through the lens of practices have been taking place in the broader SPT community which have relevance for public administration scholars seeking to adopt a SPT framework. For example, on the website *Practice Theory Methodologies* (https://practicetheorymethodologies.wordpress.com/) SPT scholars share their views and experiences with different methodologies for applying SPT.

5. A practice-oriented research agenda for public administration

Building on the calls for a practice turn set out in the previous sections, we believe the field of policy sciences could benefit from connecting more explicitly with advances on social practice theory in the broader social sciences. In this section, we suggest two key branches of scholarship within the field of policy sciences to which we think SPT can be of particular relevance in opening up new research directions. Based on the existing applications found in our review we see great value for a wider application of SPT to provide insight into (i) understanding the relation between policies and social practices of target groups, and (ii) social practices of policymaking.

5.1 Policies and the social practices of target groups

The ultimate goal of policy design is to alter the behaviour of citizens, businesses and other actors so as to bring about certain desired impacts. As such, there is a long tradition within the field of policy studies of trying to understand how policies are being received by ultimate target populations and their success or failure at bringing about collective action. An important insight in this regard is that the relationship between policies and their effect on the actions of target groups is not straightforward. In particular, there are two challenges to which SPT can offer new and valuable insights, by moving away from focusing on target populations toward understanding target practices.

The first challenge regards the issue of who or what to target in order to achieve change. Policy scholars have highlighted how the choice of a target group is an intrinsically value-

laden exercise. In their seminal work on the social construction of policy recipients, Schneider and Ingram (1997) show how assumptions held by policy makers about which societal groups are deserving or undeserving of interventions as well as the priorities and perceived effectiveness of different types of interventions play a key role in the selection of instruments, and as such may reproduce dominant biases and stereotypes.

Second, policy scholarship suggests that policies may be interpreted in different ways, both as a result of diversity of (administrative) cultures and how policies are communicated (Bell 2021; Hajer 2003; Yanow 1996). Consequently, public policies are assumed to produce different (behavioural) responses depending on both individual and contextual traits. Although this presumption meanwhile has found broad resonance within the field, the precise mechanisms that connect policy design and target group behaviour remain relatively underexplored. Policy design scholars have recently started to address this gap by adopting mechanistic approaches to uncover the causal pathways that link policy variables and behaviours of target populations (Biesbroek and Candel 2020; Capano and Howlett 2021). The emergence of the sub-field of behavioural public administration can be explained as originating from such a quest.

With regard to these challenges, integrating SPT approaches into policy sciences work focused on understanding and targeting the actions of target populations implies a series of shifts in terms of analytical focus and methods employed in policy science and practice. Most fundamentally, it calls for moving away from an emphasis on "target populations" or "target behaviours" to instead focus on "target practices". This involves attending to the situatedness and embeddedness of target practices within time, space, contexts and the lived lives of members of the target population (which in practice terminology are studied as "carriers of practices" or "practitioners").

The focus in targeting practices instead of populations includes reframing research and policy questions to ask how problematic "behaviours", such as car driving or unhealthy eating, are not understood as characteristics of people or their interpretations of policies but rather as features of dominant social practices, that have evolved at the intersection of reinforcing developments within a system (see Watson et al. 2020).

Shove and colleagues (2015) – for example in their analysis of the emergence of car dependency in the UK – reveal how social practices (such as mobility, work and shopping) and the systems of provision and infrastructures that underpin them have coevolved together over time in an overall process of spatial distancing between sites and services. These developments, which have included large scale car-centric infrastructural projects, suburbanization, and a shift from localised daily food shopping to less frequent weekly shopping in large supermarkets, have resulted in increasing numbers of the population – including new social categories such as women and lower socio-economic groups – becoming recruited to and dependent on car driving as a way of moving around in their daily lives.

Understanding and studying the relations between householders (or other target groups') practices and the wider complexes of practices in which they are enmeshed provides important insights for policy scholars. Specifically, paying attention to the ways in which specific links between practices, such as everyday food practices and dynamics occurring in normative, provisioning and institutional settings, come to be and form more or less stickier configurations that lock-in certain development trajectories is an important focal point. Instead of focusing on target populations, the emphasis should

be placed on understanding target practices and their embeddedness within bundles and systems of practices, and the role of policies therein.

To date little research within both policy sciences and the field of the sociology of practices has explored the processes and mechanisms by which policy shapes action empirically over longer timescales from a situated, experiential practice-based frame of analysis. Such ethnographic insight is important for revealing insights into how polices and social institutions shape what we do and how that emerges to be. Methodologically, this also implies a shift away from prioritizing insights from large scale survey methods to provide more room for methodologies and approaches that enable understanding of situated conduct.

5.2 Social practices of policymaking, policy work and public administrators

Despite public administration scholars' interest in the inner workings of government, there is a surprising lack of an integrated research agenda on what it is that civil servants actually "do", for what reasons, and with what outcomes (Colebatch, Hoppe, and Noordegraaf 2010; Howlett and Walker 2012). Despite aforementioned studies on policymaking practices, the tendency is all too often to aggregate administrative activities into generic clusters, such as "policy analysis" or "policy advice", that are far removed from policy practitioners' complex understandings of their work (Colebatch 2006), resulting in false dichotomies, e.g. between policy formulation and implementation (Polman and Alons 2021).

We know that the various roles middle-range civil servants fulfil are highly dependent on the broader institutional context in which these officials operate (Page 2012). Similarly, bottom-up studies of policy implementation have shown how differences in contextual constraints and demands may cause street-level bureaucrats to develop coping practices that significantly shape policy outcomes, which may even result in unethical practices such as racial profiling (Lipsky 1980).

However, research on "policy work" is still in its relative infancy. Apart from a number of (edited) volumes (e.g. Colebatch and colleagues' [2010], Howlett and colleagues' [2017]), there are still large conceptual and methodological gaps in studying governmental practices. The challenge here is to more systematically conceptualise what policymaking practices are – such as sense-making or strategizing – and how they shape policy outputs and outcomes (Sarpong, Botchie, and Dey 2018).

While much has been said within sociology about the limits of behaviourism and the implications of shifting to practices as the unit of analysis, much less focus has been placed on how to govern change from the perspective of policy work or the practices of policy and decisionmakers themselves. In other words, much research has now been conducted that studies social practices within everyday life and domestic settings but far less work analyses the emergence, performance and embeddedness of practices of policy work. In this respect, we argue that cross fertilizing insights and approaches from policy sciences and critical social practice scholarship has the potential to make a significant contribution.

Adopting a SPT analysis of practices of policymaking would also involve situating current practices within a wider socio-historical framework to study and trace how policy work and its embeddedness have evolved over time within, and across, specific

government jurisdictions. Studying practice trajectories is crucial for better understanding how changing ideologies and intersecting socio-material contexts influence the evolution and changing constitution of policy work, including how certain practices emerge, become locked-in or disappear over time. It is particularly interesting to study how policymaking practices respond when faced with new development ideas or discourses.

A SPT approach to policy work may also include a process of zooming in to examine how specific elements of practice (including meanings/ideologies, forms of knowhow and materials) are mobilised within the performance of a specific policymaking practice, as well as zooming out to explore the wider system of practices to which it is enmeshed and connected (cf. Nicolini 2012). Thinking about the relation between governing practices and the conduct of daily life, the significance of rules and standards has been highlighted in several practice theoretical accounts. For example, Giddens (1984) distinguishes between "explicit rules" and "rules of social life", which govern and are applied in the enactment and reproduction of social practices. Practices related to policy work are just as affected by specific rules and habits as other daily practices. A practice-based approach to policy work could thus entail exploring how governing practices and policies are shaped by and reproduce various "knowledge regimes", discourses and ideologies, such as those associated with the logics of behaviourism, positivism and neoliberal economic rationalities, as well as how these eclipse other forms of knowledge.

Policymakers and experts can form communities with shared practices, producing common repertoires of routines and stories, as stressed by the literature on communities of practice (Wenger 2010). These communities are also places where practices are (re)negotiated and transformed (Hargreaves 2011). On this matter SPT can shed new light on how public administrations change their views based on insights from experts, scientists and practical experiences, and contribute to the literature on policy learning in which these social and interactive processes have been underdeveloped (Polman 2018).

Moreover, integrating a SPT perspective into this line of inquiry would entail paying more specific attention to how policy work and learning play out in a polycentric governance landscape. Such situated insights are critical for understanding under what conditions and social interactions routinised policy work assumptions and practices can become destabilsed and change. Understanding the conditions and contexts under which policy work practices are more or less open to influence and transformation is of immense importance when considering the policy processes required for dealing with the vast social and ecological challenges of contemporary societies.

Methodologically, a practice-agenda for studying "policy work", would again involve conducting deep ethnographic studies to explore how policy work plays out in practice, including how ideologies, assumptions and discourses about the nature of human behaviour and how to change it are mobilised, and different socio-material conditions and constraints present themselves in situated policymaking processes.

6. Conclusion and discussion

This paper started with the observation that, in contrast to neighbouring disciplines in the social sciences, the practice turn has had only limited impact within the public administration and policy sciences. To this end, we have argued that advances in SPT associated with understanding the routine, contextual and performative character of

social life offer a promising framework for addressing some existing gaps in public administration research, and an alternative or supplementary approach to the more common behavioural public administration scholarship. While SPT and behavioural approaches rest on different ontological and epistemological foundations, the complexity and wickedness of contemporary challenges, such as climate change and sustainability transitions, call for epistemological pragmatism and pluralism (e.g. Beaumont and De Coning 2022; Nash et al. 2017). This enables researchers and practitioners to draw strategically on diverse perspectives to better understand policy problems and design more robust responses.

Our review of public administration literature reveals that, as of yet, there has been limited engagement with SPT in this academic field. Where engagement does exist, our analysis shows that public administration scholars predominantly turn to SPT for two key reasons: as an alternative to the behavioural foundations of policy interventions, and to go beyond rationalist understandings of policymaking. In addition, we see that applications of SPT bring some methodological challenges in representation that call for the use of more context-sensitive ethnographic methodological tools capable of capturing dynamics of routine life over time and across space.

Building on this review, we outline an agenda for integrating SPT to policy studies. Building a bridge between policy sciences and advances in (environmental) sociology, we see systematic opportunities for using SPT in order to develop two major strands of policy research focused on (1) understanding the targets and effects of policies (2) understanding the dynamics of policymaking itself. First, with regard to understanding the targets and effects of policies, SPT starts from the assumption that behaviour is often the result of longer deeply rooted societal developments, and is a feature of dominant social practices, instead of individual interpretations of policies. Therefore, we argue that policy studies should focus more on target practices instead of target populations to explore how patterns of social action develop, are reinforced or change, and the role of policies in reinforcing or disrupting them.

Second, applying SPT to practices of policymaking challenges scholars to think about current policymaking practices within a wider socio-historical framework. Policymaking reproduces existing knowledge regimes, discourse, and ideologies. Studying practice trajectories can improve our understanding of the effects of changing ideologies and intersecting socio-material contexts on the evolution of policy work, including how these practices are reinforced, change, or disappear. For example, current trends towards increased polycentrism within governance practice and innovations can be studied as rooted in changing trajectories and histories of practices which (continuously) vary over time and across space.

In order to address the major crises and challenges of this time, such as climate change and the energy transition, changes are required across society and policy domains. Theories of social practice offer a helpful approach to identify the interactions between crises and the bundles of practices that are connected to these crises. SPT can be applied to other fields of interest of policy scholars, that go beyond the scope of this article, such as leadership practices (see Raelin 2017), the organization and repertoires of contention of social movements (e.g. Tilly 2010), and alternative forms of social organization taking place within networks of collective action, such as food sharing or new collective forms of dividing labour (Yates 2015).

Some may argue that a limitation of SPT is that due to its context-sensitivity inferential steps to other locations and applications – which is part of the rationalistic behaviourist logic – is not always feasible, or that the policy solutions require fundamental shifts in political culture that are perceived as unpopular or unfeasible (Barr and Prillwitz 2014, 14). Nevertheless, major challenges also may require major changes, and SPT can provide valuable new insights and ideas to both policy scholars and policymakers (Hampton and Adams 2018; Keller, Halkier, and Wilska 2016), particularly by uncovering processes and mechanisms of social change not captured by aggregate and behaviourist methodologies. Moreover, scholars are increasingly exploring how to effectively use SPT to change policy approaches, such as developing research strategies and interventions together with policymakers (e.g. Watson et al. 2020). SPT can offer a fertile starting point to expand the narrow scope of models for individual behavioural change toward realizing more sustainable social practices, by providing a broader and embedded understanding of social change.

Note

1. We selected Public Administration as the category with the most overlap with policy sciences.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the authors.

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